Empathy Map

Phase 1: Brainstorming & Ideation

1. Target User

The initial target user is a traveller who wants to plan a short trip without spending excessive time arranging preferences and activities. The person may be a student, family member or small group organizer. This is a design persona for the project, not a claim that a formal interview study was conducted.

2. What the User Says

The user may express a need such as “I want a plan for these dates and this budget,” “I need activities that match our interests,” or “I want to save this plan so I can check it later.” These statements represent likely needs to guide interface design and should be validated with real users if the project is extended.

3. What the User Thinks

The user may wonder whether the itinerary fits the available time, whether the cost estimate is reasonable, and whether the suggested activities suit the group. These concerns imply that the app should display a readable plan and label AI-generated costs as estimates rather than presenting them as guaranteed prices.

4. What the User Does

The user enters a starting city and destination, chooses travel dates, provides a budget and traveller count, selects interests and travel style, and requests an itinerary. After generation, the user reviews the plan, saves or prints it, and may follow the map-search links to research accommodation or food options.

5. What the User Feels

The user may feel overwhelmed when comparing many sources, uncertain about how to distribute activities across days, or relieved when the first draft is organized. The interface should therefore avoid unnecessary complexity and keep the main actions visible.

6. Pain Points and Desired Gains

- Pain: travel information is spread across multiple pages. Gain: one form collects the core preferences.
- Pain: an attraction list is not a schedule. Gain: a day-wise itinerary provides a starting structure.
- Pain: generated work can be lost. Gain: Saved Trips makes plans retrievable.
- Pain: food preferences can be overlooked. Gain: restaurant search terms can include a chosen preference, while users still verify suitability.
- Pain: estimates can be mistaken for live prices. Gain: clear labels and limitations set realistic expectations.

7. Design Implications

The interface should use clear field labels, display generation progress, explain errors in understandable language, and distinguish generated recommendations from verified facts. The saved-trip flow should be predictable, and the external map search should be clearly identified as a separate service. This empathy map is a working design hypothesis rather than evidence of completed interviews.